corporates to purchase goods from farmers outside of the APMCs. The Congress had included in its 2019 national manifesto that if brought to power, it would abolish the APMC system. Sharad Pawar, former Union agriculture minister during the UPA regime and president of the NCP, in his autobiography had advocated for direct access to private markets for farmers and doing away with APMCs.[14] He had even written to several chief ministers in his capacity as the Union agriculture minister in 2010 to seek their support to 'encourage the private sector in providing competitive marketing channels in the overall interest of the farmers'.[15] But when it came to collecting political brownie points by piggybacking on the protesting farmers, all these opposition parties took a complete U-turn and made the protesting farmers guinea pigs to achieve their political motives.

To drive my point home that the Opposition created a slugfest out of a non-issue, let us consider an example of when the former prime minister Manmohan Singh heading the UPA government in 2004 had said,

> We need a second green revolution, making use of modern advances […] For that we need to revitalize India's research agricultural system, India's extension system, India's credit system. The more we commercialize our agriculture, the more our farmers need access to commercial inputs and that was a modernization of our agriculture credit system. There are other rigidities because of the whole marketing regimes set up in the 1930s which prevent our farmers from selling their produce where they get the highest rate of return. It is our intention to remove all those handicaps which come in the way of India realizing its vast potential as one large common market.[16]

In fact, when Prime Minister Modi spoke in the Rajya Sabha on these bills, he responded to the former prime minister's comments, 'Manmohan Singh talked about it but Modi is having to do it now. Be proud.'[17]

Scarily, the crowd at the protest sites was rolling over the upcoming months, which meant that several folks chose to return to the villages and sent over other members of their families. What this catalysed was a spread of the infection to rural parts of the states of Punjab and Haryana, where the bulk of the protestors came from. A close look at COVID-19 case data from Punjab demonstrates that the declining of the post first-wave curve halted its downward trend by January 2021 and turned into a flat line for a month